Blanquerna–Ramon Llull University, School of Communication and International Relations, Official Master's degree in Advanced Studies in International Affairs

Subject: Introduction 14148. Introduction to the History of International Relations

CONSIGNE : Write an essay reflecting upon the progressive establishment of one international system using at least one of the three compulsory readings of the course and any additional material the student may find.

Maximum length: 900 words

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In the 1970's, the German historian Reinhart Koselleck in the book *The Practice of Conceptual History,* defined the concept of Satellzeit. For him, it's a period of deep cultural change that marks the end of the Early Modern Era and the beginning of the Modern Era. Politically, it belongs to the period of Nation-States and the beginning of if not collaboration, interchange between great powers. But, in this introduction, it is fundamental to ask ourselves what is "an international system"? What are its characteristics and why, in this particular context of time, various factors made the creation of an international mechanism ? Maybe we can already, as a first reflection, establish that an international system could be a set of links, attributes or values, such as, cooperation, war, states, that are commonly shared between all the actors that compose this international system. However, the international system, throughout history, has shaped itself, depending on the historical context, the different frames and timelines, that shaped what nowadays we know as 'International system'. *How an "international system" was progressively settled, in a gradual way, going from regional systems to a global international system ? What factors contributed to this, and can we say that it's a factor of globalization, or, Western imposition?*
We will try to tackle this question, based on the readings of Christopher Alan Bayly, British historian, professor in Cambridge and specialized in the transition to the "modern world" and imperial history, as well as a chapter from *International Systems in World History: Remaking the Study of International Relations,* by Barry Buzan, political scientist and Richard Little. Both references are in the appendix.

First of all, we have to ask ourselves, how did we pass from various regional orders, completely somehow disconnected, to a unique system based on multilateral exchange. If we strictly follow, Buzan and Little (2000), the international system, understood as human societies, were based on various regional systems/ orders that are connected through regional interaction but that had no influence within themselves. The definition of the international system is, the link itself of the interaction : is it strong or not, what exchange ? [1](Buzan, 2000). Before, there were separate regional systems. It was, some regional bubbles, each one governed by their own rules, *"but with regular interaction, within a geographical region"*[2] *(*Buzan,2000). They give the example of the Islamic World, structured by the Dar-El-Salam, in contrast with Europe, for example, that was structured by Westphalian balance of power. Both systems could not speak to one another, except when wars and sporadic trade occurs. It changed, when isolated systems started mingling, and for instance, with the transatlantic trade, and the rising of colonial empires, it was the beginning. Transoceanic connections, in what Buzan and little called *globalization of international interaction, started* calling Europe the central hub of these interactions. That is why, we can say, based on the reading, that the first "one international system" was a European one, when European states imposed economic and political domination, in a very centric Western global order.

According to C.A Bayly, we can situate the progressive modern international system between 1790 and 1820, because for him, we have a mass of *Converging Revolutions,* that in all senses, politically, economically, culturally, reshaped international relations. Here, thanks to all the processes that we will see now, a real international system was born. For instance, and I, personally, think that this is the main argument of Bayly, using the historical context, he argues that this "globalization" of Revolutions, made the International system, not only for the first time adopted, globally but also inevitable. Politically, the 4 main clusters of revolutions (American, French, L.A and Haitian) reshaped the international system politically, introducing the principle of Popular Sovereignty. This

[1] Part 1, The End of Old Regimes, Chap.1Old Regimes and "Archaic Globalization" p-27-49 + Part 3 State and Society in the age of the third revolution: Polite and Commercial Peoples. p.249
[2] Buzan and Little, *International Systems in World History*, 245.

made the International system, that as we saw, was isolated, and divided in regional frames, expand, and a more uniform international system composed of *like units*, such as the States, that were uniform.[3] States are from now, the unique political actor, and participated in creating only one international system. Is it economically the same ? How do we progress towards an *unprecedented compression of time and space ?*[4] *(*Bayly, 2004*)*

The Industrial Revolution, impulsed global connections. With Steampower, and mechanization, the productivity increases, and the world becomes "smaller". We can produce everywhere and in a record time. But it also created dependence. The chain of production creates goods and services but also needs. The connection between the colonies and the metropoles becomes more strong, even though it is desequilibrated. Manufactured goods circulate freely, in the newly opened markets, but European control makes the structures of globalization unbalanced. Not only, in production, but also, in intellectual and cultural means. More and more, we can translate *one international system* to *a European- centered paradigm.* Science, Knowledge, and even the political model, are probed from a European thermometer, and we advance towards the formulation of Bayle : The Global uniformity of modern knowledge[5].(Buzan, 2000). To sum it up, we can see that the *converging revolutions* are mingled, with Eurocentric imposition, of their *international system.* In all these references, revisionism tends to have a growing influence.
This Paulitanian Revolution consolidated these 19th century transformations into institutional form. We went from various different political scales, to what we have in this 19th century : homogeneous units, known as sovereign states, that are interacting with each other by diplomacy and war, not only in Europe, but globally. But this globalization, doesn't mean an equal international system. Yes we go towards one international system, but not equal. As Barry Buzan and Richard Little, showed, we can differentiate the modern state system, from the other ones, by *"the global spread of State form"*[6] . Each one has to enter the State model. However, this apparent imposition created inequalities. Indeed, creating a rule, where some are States, and others are political entities, that are not defined like this, create a standard of civilization that in some terms, justifies, which are okay to colonize and which are not. (see p.269 of the same source). Economically, it was the same. Some were "in" this international system, and others were not. It's what the author calls a *Peripheric Structure.* Universal principles, such as the one that characterized the Revolutions of 1790-1820 does not apply to everyone. Therefore we can question this appellation of *One international system.*

To conclude this essay, and even though, we started answering this question, all along the essay, the main aspects of the lectures, strives to ask us a central question : Do this international system, is a fruit of Globalization, from a gradual transition, or, on the contrary, a Western imposition, following our both sources. This question is not an easy one. The modern international system emerged, thanks to the *Converging Revolutions.* As both of our authors try to demonstrate, everything is biased. These converging revolutions are due to the projections of Europe, and we can see that throughout the 19th century : Imperial domination, capitalism, are first European concepts that have been exported. So yes, and as Bayle notes, in page 118, the *World became one,*[7] But at what price ? Universal system, is at first a relation of dominator/dominated, where a clear hierarchy is established.

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[3] Buzan and Little, *International Systems in World History*, pp.255
[4] Bayly, *The Birth of the Modern World*, pp.101.
[5] Bayly , *The Birth of Modern World, pp.*115
[6] Buzan and Little, *International Systems in World History*, pp.266
[7] C.A. Bayly, *The Birth of the Modern World, 1780–1914* (Malden: Blackwell, 2004), 118

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